Apparently, while Rabbani denied such support from New Delhi, Dostum reported to the UN envoy Mahmoud Mestiri that Ukraine had supplied Masoud with thirty jet fighters while India was supporting this by providing military hardware.[56]

All this had happened before the fall of Kabul to the Taliban in September 1996, i.e. mostly under Rao's watch. Such a claim is at odds with the Rao doctrine. However, given Rao's predilection for political deception, determined foreign policy decisions (he had recognised Israel soon after coming to power, despite domestic criticism), and the non-lethal nature of such covert support, it is highly likely that India did give such support throughout the 1990s.[57] Though unable to confirm the covert element of this relationship, Krishnan Srinivasan, who was foreign secretary in 1994–95, confesses that the R&AW briefed him unusually regularly on their assessment of the situation in Afghanistan despite the issue not being top priority for the political and diplomatic leadership.[58] In Srinivasan's reading, the R&AW's focus on Afghanistan was essentially because they had developed considerable expertise and contacts with the anti-Pakistan factions in the country. In fact, much before the Taliban became a force worth reckoning, powerful Mujahideen leaders including Mohammad Fahim—who would lead the United Front column into Kabul in the wake of the US military intervention in 2001—visited New Delhi multiple times in 1994–95. Srinivasan, in his capacity as foreign secretary, would be asked by R&AW to meet these leaders for lunches in Delhi hotels.

> I remember distinctly meeting with Fahim [in 1994]. Now, these people were not coming just to have a meal, and certainly not with me. So, obviously there was more going on that meets the eye. There were quite a few of them ... but nearly three to four times I had lunches, teas, etc with Afghans ... always just general chit chat, but obviously they were in Delhi for other purposes ... of course the R&AW never tells you all that they know ... but even so I was very happy with what they did say ... and I think they were giving some material support to various groups in Afghanistan.[59]

According to Indian media sources, however, such a relationship was forged after the Taliban's entry into Kabul. India began covertly flying technicians to service the UF's fleet of Russian-built helicopters, as well as advisors to train Massoud's men in anti-armour techniques.[60] Spare parts and high-altitude warfare equipment worth more than US$ 10 million were also supplied and, despite the government's denials about Indian doctors treating Rabbani's soldiers